

Sexual Antinomies in Late Modernity

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Abstract It is widely assumed that late modern societies are becoming progressively more sexually liberal, regardless of whether this is seen as beneficial or not. However, 'progress' in this direction is, in actuality, very uneven and gives rise to a number of antinomies and associated anxieties. For example, in a society where erotic imagery is commonplace in the media, there are still enormous anxieties about preserving children's sexual 'innocence' (i.e. ignorance); gay and lesbian chic exists alongside continued homophobic harassment and violence; queer destabilization of heterosexual norms co-exists with claims for inclusion into homosexual institutions; tolerance of pre-marital, even casual, sex and of marital breakdown and serial relationships co-exists with intolerance of teenage pregnancy and the continuing reification of monogamy. This article will explore such tensions, raising questions about the continued 'special status' of sexuality and sexual relations.

Keywords childhood sexuality, heterosexuality, monogamy, queer, sexual dysfunction

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Sexual Antinomies in Late Modernity

While postmodern analyses have promoted academic scepticism about narratives of progress, a discourse of gradual liberation still predominates within everyday and media representations of sexuality. It is widely assumed that late modern societies are becoming more liberal and open, regardless of whether this is seen as positive or negative. Yet 'progress' in this direction is, in actuality, very uneven and gives rise to a number of antinomies and associated anxieties. These anxieties centre around the specialness of sex, its status as extra-ordinary, as somehow separable from everyday special practices and routines – a source of ecstasy that lifts us beyond the mundane but also as uniquely problematic and liable to provoke disgust and revulsion. Here we will explore some examples of

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antinomies and anxieties and go on to relate these to the extra-ordinariness of sex and to the ways in which the illusion of escape that sex offers itself provokes anxiety. While we are making an intervention into debates on social change and sexuality, we raise more issues than we are able to resolve. At this juncture we seek to identify contradictions and tension that require further investigation rather than to provide a conclusive analysis.

A number of commentators have drawn attention to the liberalization of both sexual regulation and wider sexual attitudes since the 1960s, which, superficially at least have enabled a freeing up of sexuality. There is empirical evidence from survey data, such as British Social Attitudes surveys, of the acceptance of pre-marital heterosexual sexual relations being widespread from the 1980s, and, more equivocally, greater tolerance of gay sexuality among younger generations (Harding, 1988; Heath and McMahon, 1991; Barnett and Thomson, 1996).¹ Younger people have also been reporting earlier first sex and increased numbers of sexual partners over the last two decades (Wellings et al., 1994; Johnson et al., 2001). There is also evidence from numerous smaller qualitative studies of a diversity of sexual communities, values and practices within late modern societies.² The impression of a sexually freer, more diverse society is reflected in representations of sexuality and intimate relations in popular culture and reinforced by the everyday knowledge gained from living in a social environment increasingly saturated with sexual imagery.

What are we to make of such trends? The answer is far from clear. There are those who urge caution over too eager a celebration of new sexual freedoms. Feminists, for example, point to the continued existence of gender hierarchy in heterosexual relations and the persistence of sexual violence. They have also long been aware that sexual liberation could impose new forms of constraint (see Jackson and Scott, 1996). Early Foucauldian accounts concurred, in that the incitement to have more and better sex is as much a function of power as are injunctions against sexual activity (see for example Heath, 1982). Recently, however, sociologists have been more inclined to celebrate diversity and fluidity in sexual relations in keeping with these late/postmodern times as, for example, in Giddens' (1992) account of plastic sexuality and the 'pure relationship' and Roseneil's (2000) identifying of 'queer' tendencies in contemporary sexual mores. Yet queer lifestyles are not equally accessible to all, not even to all lesbians and gays, but only to those with the economic and cultural capital necessary to access the increasingly commodified cultural spaces that queer inhabits (Hennessy, 1995, 2000).

Making sense of these tensions entails more than an awareness of both continuity and change. It is not simply that some things change while others stay the same, it is that these changes and continuities throw up tensions and contradictions around sexuality that, we feel, are indicative

of a persistent unease about the sexual that sits side by side with an acceptance of greater sexual freedom and diversity. Here we will explore this using four examples: children and childhood, heterosexual monogamy, heterosexuality and sexual difference, and the urge to sexual perfection.

Children and childhood

In a society where erotic imagery is commonplace in the media, there are still enormous anxieties about preserving children's sexual 'innocence' (i.e. ignorance). While censorship in the UK, as in much of Europe, is now very relaxed (for example, the new British guidance on film classification) conditions under which children are offered any sex education in British and US schools are increasingly constrained³ and the availability of sexual information and imagery to children remains a subject of public concern.

Children and sex are seen as antithetical, both being defined as special and bracketed from the 'real' world. Thus there is little focus on becoming sexual as a process; rather it is seen as a matter of leaping a chasm between 'innocence' and 'knowledge'. Thus adults, especially parents, have difficulty in seeing children as potentially sexual (and vice versa), which creates anxieties about children and young people's access to sexual knowledge and even greater anxieties about their sexual practices. The problem is exacerbated by the tendency, first noted by sociologists decades ago (Gagnon and Simon, 1974; Jackson, 1982), to judge children as sexual through the filter of adult sexual scripts. Thus a child's talk or actions can be deemed sexual, and hence problematic, from an adult point of view when it has no such meaning for the child.

Becoming sexual, therefore, is not seen as a routine taken-for-granted part of growing up, but something to be hedged around with cautions, warnings and prohibitions. Many parents profess a desire to be open with their children about sexuality, but even those who claim to have achieved this, when questioned more closely, may turn out to be defining openness in rather narrow terms (Botcherby and Scott, 2003). Moreover, in the current climate of anxiety about sexual abuse, conduct once thought conducive to sexual openness, such as a casual attitude to nudity or bathing with children, is now open to interpretation as abusive. A child who has had free access to sexual knowledge, who knows 'too much', can be defined as a victim of abuse. Such concerns can only heighten uncertainty about how and when to allow children access to sexual knowledge or how to respond to children beginning to express themselves sexually. Few adults in the UK look positively, or even with understanding, on teenage sexual experimentation and indeed compared to the rest of northern Europe the British seem to be particularly prudish.

Here contemporary sexual attitudes are not as positive as they are often

thought to be. There is an irony at the heart of the rhetoric of sexual openness: it is considered a good thing, and members of late modern societies are increasingly willing to discuss it openly in public, yet this public openness is accompanied by a private unease. Thus even those who proclaim the necessity of openness with children find it difficult to talk easily to their own children about sex. The view of sex as fulfilling and life enhancing seems to be undermined by the concurrent view that it is anti-thetical to the well being of the young. Sex may be a wonderful thing but only, apparently, within strict limits and when marked 'for adults only'.

This tension is further complicated by the difficulty we have in deciding precisely what an adult is. While there is greater tolerance of pre-marital freedoms among adults this has been matched by a concomitant increase in anxiety about teenage sexual experimentation and especially teenage pregnancy. Yet it might be precisely such intolerance that contributes to the higher teenage pregnancy rate in the UK compared with the other European countries most notably The Netherlands. Young people in The Netherlands tend to have their first experience of heterosexual intercourse on average 15 months later than their counterparts in Britain, and when they do have intercourse they are more likely to use contraception (Lewis, 2002; Silver, 2002). This does not mean that Dutch young people are sexually inactive prior to 'going all the way' but that in the context of a more sex positive culture they are more able to make choices about their activities and are less likely to define sex narrowly in terms of penis/vagina penetration (Silver, 2002). In Finland rates of teenage pregnancy and sexually transmitted diseases (STDs) are low despite generally less sophisticated sex education than in the UK. A likely explanation of this is the provision in Finland of a supportive school health system where young people can go for advice and contraception, and once again a more sex positive culture than is to be found in Britain (Hosie, 2001).

Heteronormativity and monogamy

The sexual world that children ultimately learn about, and come to participate in, continues to be ordered by institutionalized heterosexuality. Despite greater acceptance, even valorization, of sexual diversity, the heterosexual couple remains enshrined as the normative form of adult sexual relationship. Again there has been change – far greater openness and acceptance is evident, for example, in popular culture where every soap, police and hospital drama has its lesbian or gay characters and 'queer' TV personalities humorously ridicule straight conventions.

The evidence we have is equivocal and suggestive of the tensions and contradictions in contemporary understandings of queer sexualities. This is the case even within popular culture where signs of 'queer tendencies'

in contemporary social mores are most easily discerned (see e.g. Roseneil, 2000). In the first place, there may be more continuity that is generally acknowledged between contemporary 'queer' celebrities and their antecedents in 19th-century music hall, pantomime and the stock camp characters of post-war British comedy, who also commonly mocked heterosexual mores.⁴ Moreover, the playful celebration of queerness exists alongside and fails to challenge an equally potent popular cultural discourse – that of the 'natural', evident in representations of 'scientific discoveries' and particularly genetics. The idea of being 'born that way' far from being challenged by most of the gay community is often welcomed. Queer, it seems, can be as playful, ironic and chic as you like – but it is still innate. Here the fluidity associated with queer in its academic sense vanishes and is replaced with a fixity that sits uneasily with the idea of unsettling the heteronormative.

The 'harder' evidence of survey data is equally unsatisfactory as a reliable indicator of common-sense understandings of sexual diversity. Measures of 'social attitudes' simply cannot capture the complex and context-specific aspects of everyday thought and practice. Many people may think they are tolerant of homosexuality (just as most think they are free from racism), but what they say they think when completing an attitude survey may be a long way from the practical reasoning and gut reactions that inform their everyday conduct. For example many young gays and lesbians become homeless because of parental intolerance of their sexuality (Prendergast et al., 2002) – yet it is not inconceivable that someone who cannot cope with a gay son would express tolerance towards homosexuality if responding to an attitude survey. The concept of tolerance is, of course, itself problematic since it implies that there is something that might be intolerable, or at least problematic, around which to mobilize tolerance. The surveys in any case suggest that there are limits to such 'tolerance' (see, for example, Barnett and Thomson, 1996).

Acceptance, moreover, has its price in the heterosexualization of all sexual relationships. Gay and lesbian relationships are more accepted if they are long-term, monogamous and stable and if they buy into the dominant 'family values' of normative heterosexuality. Increasingly claims to basic citizenship rights are based upon the heterosexual norm. While it may seem straightforwardly just and equitable that gay partnerships should gain the recognition due to married heterosexual couples, such claims for rights buy into highly conventional lifestyles that not everyone – whether straight or gay – would want to endorse. Not only does this political strategy institutionalize heterosexuality as a standard to be aspired to (Rahman and Jackson, 1997), but it also, and importantly, privileges sexual coupledness over all other relationships. Once again, sexuality is over-valued – in this case as definitive of the only relationships that matter,

downgrading significant relationships, such as close friendships, which are not sexual.

This also serves to redefine the boundaries of the normative, between those who live in couples and those – gay or straight – who choose not to. Thus yet another binary can be brought into existence: the distinction between the good homosexual and the dangerous queer (Smith, 1997). The politically or even academically queer, that which seeks to destabilize heterosexuality, is accorded neither credence nor tolerance, but cultural manifestations of queerness are less often seen as dangerous. Those spaces where an exuberant queer culture is permitted to flourish may be contained and commodified, but they are also normalized as tourist spectacle. A ‘gay village’ has become a ‘must’ for any city to be marketed as lively and cosmopolitan and is welcomed in so far as it does not rock the boat too much. Queer has become ‘chic’ and having what it takes to ‘blend in’ in gay or queer settings is a sign of cultural capital (cf. Skeggs, 2003).⁵ Yet the social cachet of gay and lesbian chic sits alongside continued homophobic harassment in the workplace and violence on the street, not to mention the fact that it is still acceptable, in some eminently respectable circles, to condemn homosexuality as an ‘abomination’.⁶

Thus even if the ‘queer’ is often publicly tolerated and sometimes even celebrated, it is only within certain limits and it seems premature to suggest that it is seriously unsettling heterosexual hegemony. Its effects are far more uncertain and contradictory. To go further, to argue that heterosexuality itself is becoming a little queer (Roseneil, 2000) seems unwarranted. It certainly is the case that heterosexual family relations are no longer as stable as they once were – that there is more cohabitation, later marriage, more divorce, more single parenthood and so on – which may be signs that couple relationships are no longer as durable, but not necessarily that they have lost their salience or their appeal.

Greater tolerance of pre-marital, even casual, sex and of marital breakdown and serial relationships co-exists with the continuing reification of monogamy. It is difficult, these days, to find any area of adult sexual conduct that most people will unequivocally say is wrong – the one exception seems to be sexual infidelity, especially adultery. Here again, though, we encounter a mis-match between attitudinal data and actual practice. Almost everyone says that sexual infidelity is wrong, yet it is widespread enough for it to be likely that many of those who disapprove of it in principle are actually practising or have practiced it. Adultery still seems to be thought of as a sin, something engaged in guiltily or as a transitional stage between relationships. There is little endorsement of non-monogamy as a lifestyle or political choice even among feminists, who were once critical of monogamy (Jackson and Scott, 2003, 2004). Monogamy remains the ideal and any departure from it is seen as a personal betrayal of one’s

partner. Hence politicians can still be discredited by a sexual indiscretion so that their 'personal infidelity' comes to stand for their political untrustworthiness (Jackson, 1999; Holmes, 2000). More generally, public interest in the private sexual lives of the famous remains motivated by a mixture of prurience and prudery. With monogamy so deeply entrenched there appears to be little evidence for the queering of heterosexuality.

We are also not fully convinced by the more modest proposal that there is a move towards more contingent and conditional relationships. There is certainly evidence of lower tolerance of unsatisfactory relationships, a greater willingness to end those which fail to come up to expectations and therefore perhaps of greater critical reflexivity within relationships. However, this reflexivity does not appear to take a critical form with regard to the process of entering into serious relationships – here there continues to be an acceptance of the romantic ideal of 'til death us do part' rather than the more contingent 'til I get fed up with you'. Research suggests that people enter into marriage and long-term relationships with high ideals of togetherness and commitment and, at least on the part of women, preparedness to 'work at it' (Mansfield and Collard, 1988; Hochschild, 1990; Duncombe and Marsden, 1993; Langford, 1999). When these relationships fall apart, it is unlikely to be because contingency was built in from the outset. It is more probable, as Lynn Jamieson (1999) suggests, a result of tension between ideals of mutuality and persistent gender inequalities and the ways in which gender asymmetry is reproduced in the very ways in which intimacy is achieved in everyday life.

Equalizing heterosexual relations?

The other side of claims about change in sexual mores is the idea that heterosexual relations are undergoing 'democratization' (Giddens, 1992), that the old inequalities that once made heterosexuality so oppressive for women are being undermined. There is of course evidence that egalitarian ideals are having an impact on heterosexual relationships, indeed this is why increasing numbers of women are able to express their dissatisfaction with male partners, even to the extent of voting with their feet and leaving. Elsewhere, too, egalitarianism has become firmly embedded within contemporary discourses of heterosexual relationships. There has been an apparent erosion of the sexual double standard and an increasing emphasis on women's right to sexual pleasure and to freedom of sexual expression. Detailed discussion of women's sexual pleasure has become widespread throughout popular culture and there is now far more openness about and information on the intimate details of female sexuality than there was half a century or even 30 years ago. It also seems to be the case that women themselves are more sexually active, and have more partners than in the

past, and here there has been change even over the last decade (Johnson et al., 2001). Yet asymmetries between women and men persist – a continuation of some old ones and the addition of some newer ones.

Among the old ones, of course, is the double standard. It may have been eroded but has by no means entirely disappeared. Women remain concerned with maintaining appropriately feminine sexual respectability (Skeggs, 1997), still lack a language of autonomous female desire and pleasure and continue to experience coercive sex (Holland et al., 1992). Ideals of sexual self-expression have reshaped the old slag/drag dichotomy but have also narrowed the margins between excess and deficiency, between being too sexual and not sexual enough, thus producing an even more slippery tightrope for women to walk. The norms of decency are also classed. Middle-class women with the economic capital to ensure secure independent lifestyles and the cultural capital to conduct sexual liaisons with what is perceived as finesse and sophistication are unlikely to be labelled 'slags'. Working-class women who are too obviously sexual, however, provoke public distaste, even disgust (Skeggs, 2003) and, if sexual excess leads to an excess of fecundity, are also likely to find themselves objects of regulatory state surveillance.

At the same time there has been a renewed emphasis on sexual difference in popular culture. Evolutionary psychology has had a major impact on popular understandings of science and underpins, for example, virtually every television documentary purporting to inform us about the 'science' of sexuality and relationships. Women, we are told, are all in search of the 'alpha male' to father their offspring while men are seeking women with the ideal hip:waist ratio, who embody guaranteed fecundity. Men are seen as needing to sow their seed as widely as possible, women to find one ideal man to father their child. Such explanations allow for non-monogamous women through the idea that a woman whose mate is alpha minus (or even beta) will seek to improve her reproductive chances through a 'quickie' with an alpha plus at the moment of ovulation!! The 'truth' of human sexuality is thus reduced to a desire to maximize genetic transmission.

A discourse of sexual difference also permeates self-help guides to 'better' relationships (Tannen, 1991; Gray, 1992, 1996). Women and men are represented as being intrinsically different, of two different species, indeed even from different planets. Such differences are held to be irreducible and the way to make relationships work is to understand the 'other' or rather to persuade women to make allowances for men since these books are marketed primarily for women. Women are thus still left managing relationships and doing the emotional – and sexual – labour (Duncombe and Marsden, 1993, 1996; Langford, 1999). The appeal of these accounts might lie in an underlying philosophy of a 'different but equal' relation between the sexes. This idea is seductive in that it promises

equality without challenging what people think is central to their sense of the gendered and sexual self; yet it also naturalizes gender, leaving no space for a critique of femininity and masculinity as social constructs, still less of men's conduct in relationships as a product of their historical dominance.

The tension between egalitarian ideals and the emphasis on sexual difference finds its expression in what is often read as a new more assertive style of femininity: a femininity that is 'out and proud'.⁷ The image is that of the powerful woman who is none the less feminine, specifically sexually empowered in her push-up bra, designer clothes and her 6-inch spiked heels. High-heeled shoes, the fashion pages tell us, are emblematic of a confident, powerful femininity. Whatever their symbolic potency, stiletto heels deliver very little real power – a woman wearing them has power over a man only if he lies down and lets her walk all over him!⁸

This 'new femininity', far from being evidence of an ironic postmodern capacity to play with gender may represent an accommodation to the renewal of essentialism in popular culture. Rather than an appreciation of gender fluidity we have, once again, a fixed binary ordained by nature. It should be recognized that it is possible to be playful and ironic without necessarily challenging fixity and naturalness – and this is so with regard to both the gay/straight and male/female binaries. For example, the routine ways in which women make fun of men, be it their unsavoury bathroom habits or their emotional incapacities, can be highly ironic while simultaneously highly essentializing. Thus the effect of playful parody can reconfirm binaries rather than unsettle them.

The urge to sexual perfection

Liberating sexuality, it has been suggested, brings new constraints as does increasing reflexivity about the sexual. Sex can no longer be taken for granted, rather it must be constantly improved upon in the pursuit of perfection. As we have suggested in earlier work, to be bad at sex is almost to fail as a human being; hence the market for self-help books on improving one's technique (Jackson and Scott, 1997). Despite this pedagogy, sex is not seen as a social practice that needs to be learnt like other social practices. To admit to be in need of instruction may impact negatively on one's image and reputation, therefore the advice literature is directed towards 'advanced' practitioners rather than absolute beginners and thus the emphasis is on ever more exotic variations albeit on a fairly limited theme. Sexual fulfilment has come to be seen as a life-goal in itself the key to personal happiness (Heath, 1982). Fulfilment however remains a peculiarly gendered term it is still women's sexual satisfaction that requires the most effort to achieve. More than physical sexual satisfaction is sought as both sex and the relationship itself become projects to be worked at and

worked upon. If the couple themselves cannot solve their own problems they can now call on expert advice from a number of quarters. In particular there has been an increased medicalization of sex and a broadening of the definition of what constitutes sexual dysfunction.

Traditionally, sexual deficiency in women was defined as a lack of desire while in men inability to perform was, and continues to be, the main issue. A few decades ago women's problems were seen as primarily psychological, and men's problems as physical (Clark, 1993), whereas now physical medicine (and surgery) is increasingly defining and intervening in women's sexual 'problems' (Marshall, 2002; Moynihan, 2003). While sociologists speak of desire as constructed and postmodernists emphasize its fluidity, the medical profession is determined to fix it. This medical 'fix' has two dimensions. First, sexuality is 'fixed' in the sense of being innate, objective, measurable and physiological, something to be diagnosed as functional or dysfunctional. Second it is 'fixable', it is something to be 'corrected' or 'cured' when found to be dysfunctional through a surgical or a chemical fix. The latter, in particular, has come to the fore recently with the search for a female equivalent of Viagra and through attempts to establish 'female sexual dysfunction' as an accepted diagnostic category. Here the new essentialism is often mobilized in combination with a pseudo-feminist discourse. Where once women's sexual problems were seen as being 'all in their heads', now we are told that they are every bit as 'real' as men's and also as amenable to medical intervention.⁹ Here again, 'progress' has its down side, for women's sexuality is being 'fixed' in terms of readiness for vaginal penetration (Marshall, 2002) and thus an androcentric, heteronormative view of what sex *is*.

What's so special about sex?

At the centre of many of the contradictions surrounding sex is its status as 'special', as somehow existing outside and apart from everyday life. It is susceptible to being seen either as uniquely exciting, raising us above everyday sociality or as uniquely dangerous, undermining civilization (as we know it) and threatening to reduce us to barbarism. The positive side of this equation currently seems to have the upper hand, but there remains a strong undercurrent of what libertarians are apt to call sex negativity. Indeed libertarian arguments actually depend on this negativity, reifying the pleasures to be gained from transgression.

In everyday discourse 'better than sex' has become the ultimate accolade implying that sexual pleasure is the benchmark against which other pleasures are measured. The reason why this comparison works so well is because sexual pleasure is seen as both qualitatively and quantitatively superior to other forms of pleasure. Sex is never seen as simply an everyday

activity or just a pleasant pastime. The everyday is associated with the routine and mundane and routine and mundane sex can only ever be seen as 'bad' sex. Even to ask the question 'what's so special about sex?' or to suggest that everyday sex might be acceptable is to risk being seen as a sad person deprived of 'good' sex. Routine is, almost by definition, boring and the point of sex is to lift us beyond the quotidian. Sex is associated with spontaneity, passion and subversion and not with everyday practices such as teeth cleaning and tea drinking. A routinized sex-life is to be avoided and recipes for such avoidance are the stock in trade of advice manuals, which, paradoxically, offer us formulae to avoid formulaic sex. 'Good sex', as we have noted before is now sold as a mark of distinction (Jackson and Scott, 1987). Yet little is known, empirically, about how this relates to actual sexual practices or to other kinds of social practices.

Sex is even set apart from other special activities in that unlike other treats it is marked primarily as a private activity. While being increasingly open to public representations, sexual activity usually occurs behind closed doors and this is where most people think it should stay. While sex can be practised alone or, more rarely, with multiple partners its paradigmatic form is as an activity for couples. Indeed a key aspect of the 'specialness' of sex is as something shared, defining both the activity and the relationship as special. Thus the very sense of self, while individual, can also be vested in the couple, taking each partner beyond or out of themselves. Sex is seen as a shared practice through which each partner gets under the other's skin, which binds the couple together and renders the relationship more than the sum of its parts. Thus each sexual relationship is seen as special, unique, different from any other.¹⁰ The merging of boundaries associated with sexual intimacy produces fragility and renders us vulnerable to loss of self-confidence, self-esteem and indeed even a loss of self when relationships end. Those suffering from such loss often describe a sense of being torn apart, of feeling as though half of them is missing, of having to rebuild themselves. Such feelings can be exacerbated because of what has been valorized as special. The secret world of lovers can become a source of embarrassment and self-disgust if it is feared that intimate knowledge has escaped the confines of the relationship and is being confided to a new partner or mutual friends. For the person who initiates the ending of a relationship, separation of self may be less of a problem; indeed distance from the other is likely to have been achieved in part through a reversal of the very attraction that was once central to the relationship. Some would suggest that it is necessary to be repulsed from the one you once desired in order to break free. Repulsion is commonly seen as the other side of attraction and, when the ecstasy wears off, feelings of self-disgust at past practices and relationships are not uncommon. Waning of passion and the end of a relationship entails coming down to

earth in order to have the freedom to fall in love and thus escape into ecstasy once again! (see Langford, 1999).

Where do we go from here? Concluding thoughts

Late modern sexual mores, then, are in tension between a celebration of sexual pleasure, experimentation and diversity and a wariness of sexuality as a source of anxiety and revulsion. This is more than a case of cultural lag between progressive and retrogressive moralities since both sets of views are held simultaneously. Those who argue for openness in discussing sex with children cannot do so with their own children; those who disavow homophobia can react with horror or confusion when someone close to them is found to be lesbian or gay; those who promote women's sexual autonomy can brand as slags those who are deemed to express their sexuality inappropriately. These sexual antinomies can have ironic effects: we have ever more public disclosure of 'private' sexual lives, yet the existing empirical evidence tells us that those who can lay their sexual souls bare in public – or to researchers – find such openness problematic in their intimate relationships. We live in a state of high anxiety about sexual threats to children, yet that very anxiety precludes research on children's understandings of sexuality or on those who express sexual desires towards them. Such ironies are not simply symptoms of postmodern instabilities, but should be subjected to both critical and empirical scrutiny.

As sociologists, we need to step back from the idea that sex itself is either good or bad if we are to examine and investigate the tensions, ironies and contradictions to which sexuality gives rise. In our view it is not sex per se that is intrinsically life enhancing or debasing, oppressive or liberatory, but particular ways in which sex acts and relations are socially ordered. While the goals of 'good sex' or 'better sex' may seem to be positive ends in themselves, we need to ask what counts as 'good sex', who is defining it, why it is thought of as important, what forms of cultural or social capital accrete around it. Thus we are not calling for a more 'objective' view of sexuality, but rather for a more critical view of the special status it has acquired in common-sense, popular and academic discourse in order to investigate it in the same way as we would any other aspect of everyday social life.

Notes

1. However British Social Attitudes data reveal that tolerance has its limits. Intolerance of gay sexuality actually increased during the early and mid-1980s (Harding, 1988) – it is assumed in response to the AIDS panic – although the trend had begun to reverse by the end of the decade (Heath and McMahon, 1991). By the mid 1990s there was greater tolerance, but within limits. For example, only 27 per cent of the sampled population

- objected to explicit heterosexual sex being depicted on terrestrial TV, 54 per cent thought that gay male sex should never be shown (Barnett and Thomson, 1996).
2. Such studies are too numerous to cite effectively. In addition to studies of heterosexual relation and varied gay and lesbian lifestyles, we have studies of transgender, participants in commercial sex, serious sado-machochists and participants in sex-parties and much in between.
 3. The US government's financial incentives to the promotion of sexual abstinence in school sex education are a particularly obvious example, but in British schools, too, educators' hands are increasingly tied by directives against too much, too explicit sex education.
 4. This 'sending-up was often the precise comedic function of such characters, even if some of their humour, by today's standards, seems highly sexist and as perpetuating negative stereotypes of (particularly) gay men. Of course, contemporary exponents of this art form can now safely proclaim their own sexual preferences in a way their predecessors could not.
 5. Skeggs is particularly concerned with large groups of working-class white women, especially hen parties using Manchester's gay spaces. They are seen as alien invaders and a cause of discomfort largely as a result of class, of inappropriate taste, style and deportment, rather than sexuality – though class is rarely named by the habitués of the gay village as the source of the discomfort the women's presence produces.
 6. We were completing the revisions on this article as the debate on 'gay bishops' in the Anglican Church was at its height – events that licensed an outpouring of extreme bigotry within British broadcasting of a kind that would not have been permitted air time were it not for the cloak of respectability afforded it by religion.
 7. This characterization of femininity, borrowed, of course, from the discourse of gay pride, was used on a BBC television documentary on the Wonderbra, broadcast on 5 April 2003 in the 'Designing the Decade' series.
 8. High heels are, of course, also associated with dominatrix fantasies. But the power they deliver is only fantasized power. Shoes that make it impossible to walk fast, let alone run away from trouble do not deliver power. We wonder what we are to make of the current fashion for 'kitten heels' – marginally easier to walk in than stilettos, but which carry rather different connotations. Are these ripe for a post-feminist make-over? Is being 'kittenish' now going to be seen as empowering?
 9. See the online rapid responses to Ray Moynihan's critique of medical sexology in the British Medical Journal – especially from those who rushed to the defence of medical intervention
<http://bmj.bmjournals.com/cgi/eletters/326/7379/45>
 10. While it seems likely that actual sexual practices are similar across relationships the difficulties facing researchers in this field make it difficult for sociology to develop an analysis of sex as everyday practice.

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